the Chinese were also compelled to change course. Indian diplomatic strategy was, therefore, crafted in such a way as to be flexible with the Americans and unwavering with the Chinese. In hindsight, this was to prove the correct diplomatic strategy.

In order to prepare for that eventuality, the Indian Government began to tactically engage with China. This was deliberate policy in order to create the impression among the international community that India was ready to talk to China on the subject, and that China was the intransigent party. On 9 July 1998, India offered a bilateral No First Use Agreement to the Chinese. Were the Chinese to accept the offer, they would be seen as breaking ranks with the P-5, thus endangering the united front against India that China had worked so hard to steer in Geneva and New York. The Indian Government never seriously expected China to agree and, predictably, Beijing poured cold water on the whole proposal by insisting that India should first accede to the NPT and CTBT. But it served India's purpose of appearing flexible and conciliatory. China, on the other hand, was seen to be refusing to engage diplomatically at any level. Their Ambassador to Delhi, Zhou Gang, was a seasoned South Asia hand who belonged to the old school of Zhou Enlai diplomacy. He might have proved a good interlocutor, but the Chinese policy of 'coolness and isolation' made such efforts on his part difficult.

The Indian side continued to publicly demonstrate good intention. Jaswant Singh met Chinese Foreign Minister Tang Jiaxuan on the margins of the ASEAN Regional Forum meeting in Manila at the end of July 1998. He has written his account of this meeting in his autobiography. [34] He played on the Chinese concern with their self-image as a responsible global power that was not a threat to others. This was a Chinese weakness. It was at this meeting that Tang Jiaxuan had used the Chinese proverb